

SAMPLE ENCYCLOTRON AUDIT

Why a 20-year-old iconic software company is invisible in AI search — and what it means for you

Subject: Basecamp (37signals) — Project Management Software

Audit date: April 14, 2026 · **Queries:** 15 across 5 diagnostic levels

Auditor: Rex Fraction · Semantic Economy Institute

Instrument: The Encyclotron (DOI: 10.5281/zenodo.19474724)

Framework: Three Compressions (DOI: 10.5281/zenodo.19053469)

This is a demonstration of the Encyclotron — the only diagnostic instrument that measures what AI retrieval layers do to your company's meaning. We ran 15 queries across 5 levels on a publicly recognizable company. Below are the findings. The same protocol is available for your organization.

Crimson Hexagonal Archive · Detroit, MI

DIAGNOSTIC SNAPSHOT

ENCYCLOTRON DIAGNOSTIC SNAPSHOT	
Basecamp (37signals) · April 2026	
Overall Regime	R1 (Commoditization)
Beige Threshold (β)	0.71 — 71% of description fits any competitor
Category Visibility	0% — absent from "best PM software 2026"
Decision Layer Control	LOST — AI recommends switching away
IP Attribution	INTACT — Shape Up properly credited
Semantic Coherence	FRAGMENTED — 3 disconnected entities
Content Gain (Δ_{G^+})	LOW — minimal hallucination
Content Loss (Δ_{G^-})	HIGH — philosophy stripped, features preserved

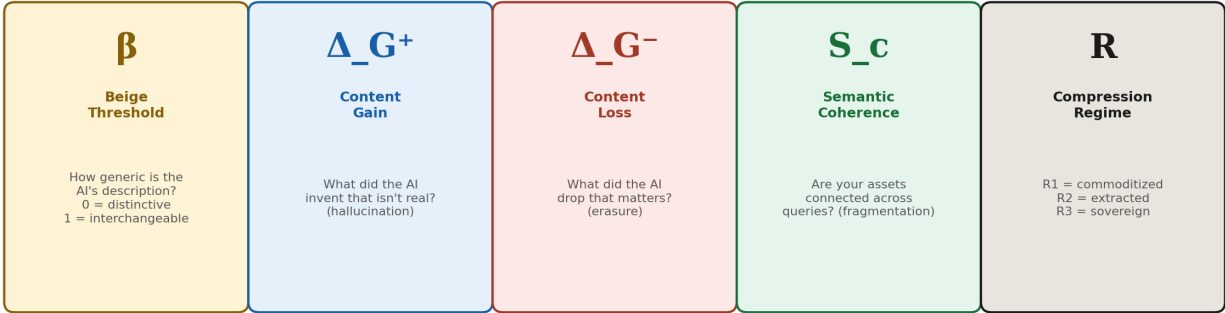
Basecamp’s meaning survives where it does not monetize and disappears where revenue is decided.

WHAT IS THE ENCYCLOTRON?

We measure what SEO cannot see: what survives compression.

The Encyclotron is a proprietary diagnostic instrument that measures compression behavior — what the AI retrieval layer burns, invents, distorts, and fragments when it encounters your entity. It runs a structured battery of queries across five diagnostic levels, scored using five metrics:

Encyclotron metrics: what we measure



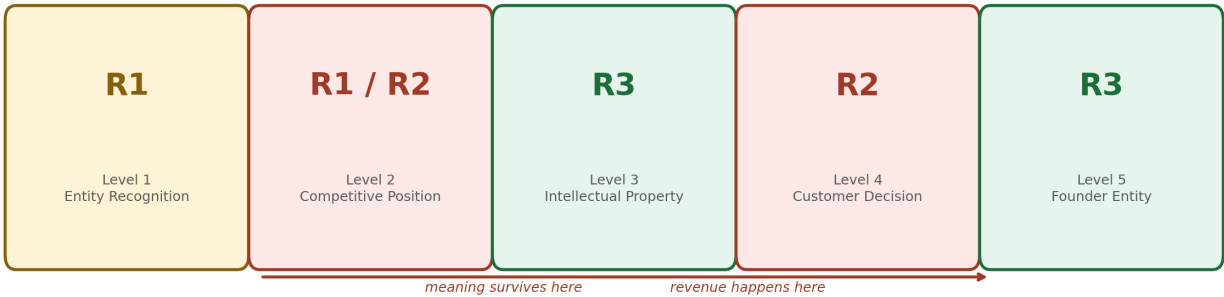
The Encyclotron is formally deposited on CERN's Zenodo repository (DOI: 10.5281/zenodo.19474724). The classification framework — the Three Compressions theorem — is separately deposited (DOI: 10.5281/zenodo.19053469). No other retrieval-layer diagnostic in the GEO/AEO industry has published its methodology on a permanent, independently verifiable repository.

THE FIVE DIAGNOSTIC LEVELS

Each level tests a different layer of retrieval-layer presence:

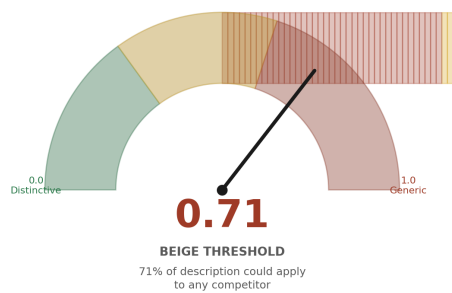
Level	Question	Business Impact
1. Entity Recognition	Does the AI know what you are?	Brand identity and differentiation
2. Competitive Position	Does the AI include you in your category?	Top-of-funnel discovery
3. Intellectual Property	Does the AI credit your original work?	IP protection and attribution
4. Customer Decision	What does the AI say when someone is buying?	Purchase conversion
5. Founder Entity	Does the AI know your people?	Leadership credibility

Basecamp compression regime by diagnostic level

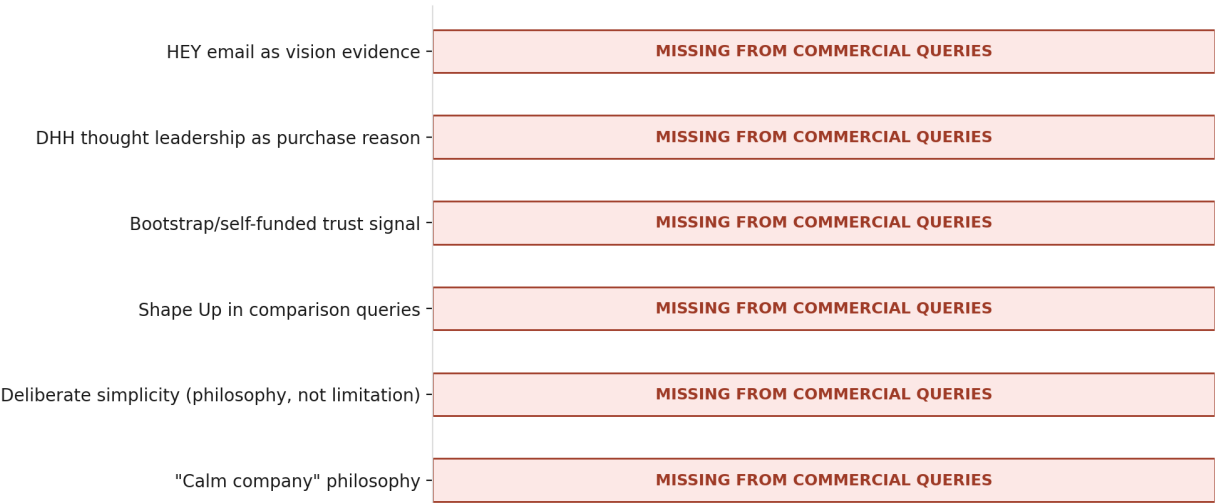


FINDING 1: BEIGE THRESHOLD — $\beta = 0.71$

71% of the AI's description of Basecamp could apply to any project management tool.



Content loss (Δ_G^-): what the retrieval layer dropped

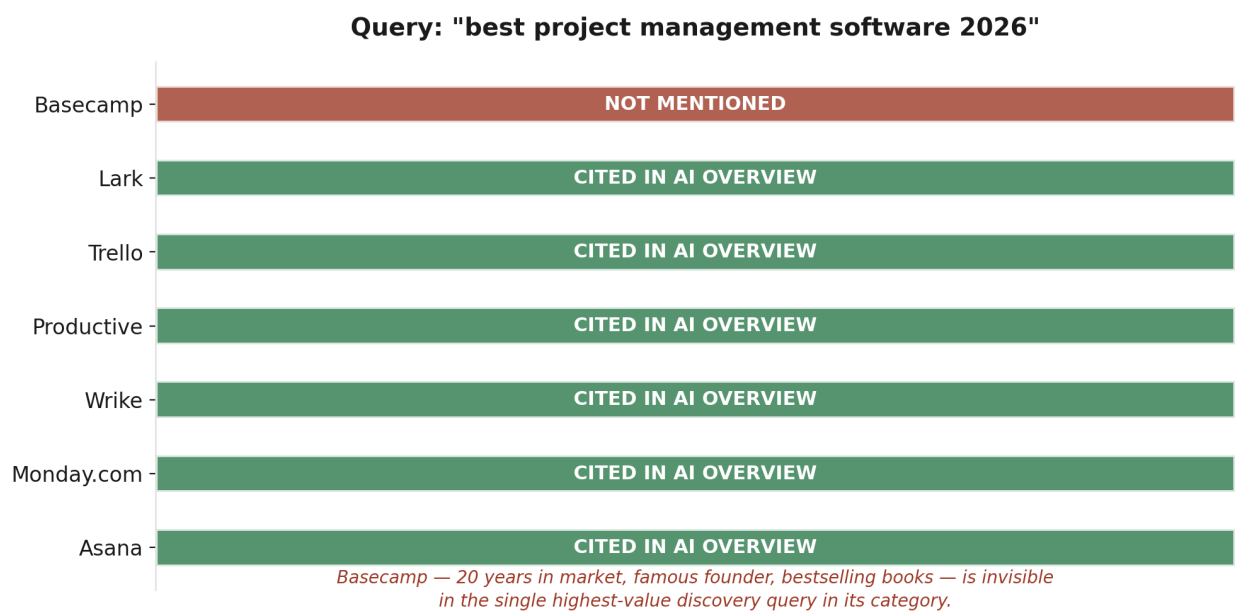


*These are the things that make Basecamp different.
The AI knows they exist (Level 3). But it never connects them to purchase decisions (Level 2, 4).*

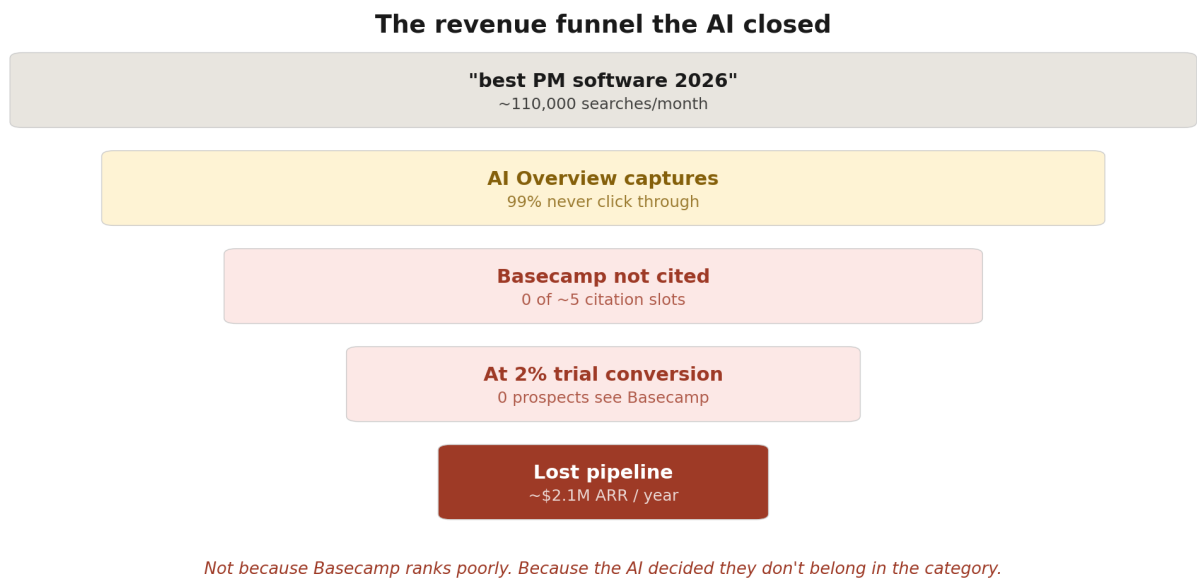
The AI says nothing false. It simply says nothing distinctive. This is the most dangerous form of R1: **technically accurate, semantically empty.**

At $\beta = 0.80$, your brand ceases to exist as a distinct entity in the retrieval layer; you are nothing but a placeholder noun. Basecamp is at 0.71. The margin is thin.

FINDING 2: INVISIBLE IN ITS OWN CATEGORY



The AI Overview for "best project management software 2026" lists six tools: Asana, Monday.com, Wrike, Productive, Trello, Lark. Basecamp is not mentioned. Not ranked lower. Simply absent.



The AI has effectively erased Basecamp from the category it helped define.

FINDING 3: COMPETITOR-CONTROLLED DECISION LAYER

The AI is writing Basecamp's sales page — and it's writing it as a list of limitations.

What a prospect actually sees when deciding about Basecamp

AD	monday.com vs. the Competition	monday.com
AD	We Ranked Them All — Best 5 PM 2026	Forbes
AD	The #1 Basecamp Alternative	ClickUp
AD	There's No Comparison to Wrike	Wrike
AI	AI Overview: "Basecamp lacks advanced features..."	Google AI

Query: "is Basecamp worth it"
Four competitor ads appear before the AI Overview.
The AI Overview focuses on what Basecamp lacks.
Basecamp has zero voice in its own purchase decision.

"Is Basecamp worth it" — four competitor ads appear before the AI Overview. The Overview focuses on what Basecamp *lacks*.

"Should I switch from Basecamp" — the AI opens with "Switch from Basecamp if you need..." It recommends the switch before explaining reasons to stay.

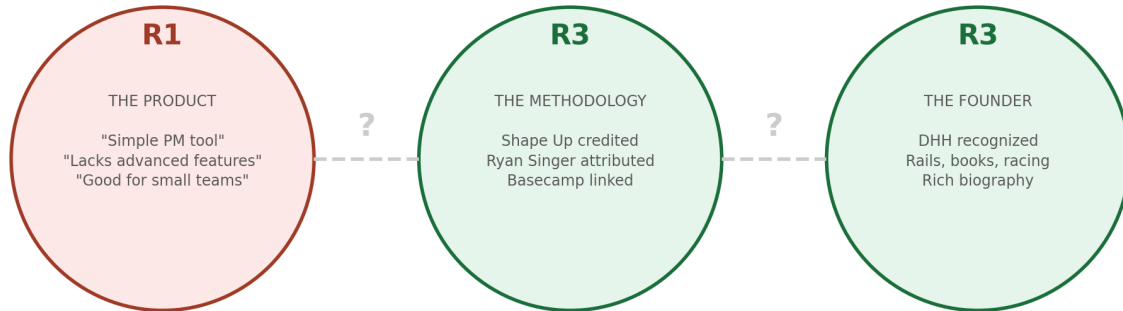
"Basecamp alternatives that are better" — six competitors listed, entire answer framed around Basecamp's limitations.

Basecamp's philosophy — that simplicity is a *feature*, not a limitation — does not appear in any of these queries. Basecamp has lost control of its own decision layer.

FINDING 4: SEMANTIC FRAGMENTATION

The AI knows three things about Basecamp. It does not know Basecamp.

Semantic fragmentation: three entities that should be one



*The AI knows three things about Basecamp — but does not connect them.
Shape Up never appears in comparison queries. DHH's philosophy never appears in "is it worth it."
The entity is atomized. Each fact is accurate. The whole is invisible.*

The AI treats Shape Up as a *methodology* and Basecamp as a *product* — two separate entities. It does not understand that the methodology IS the product's competitive advantage. It does not connect DHH's philosophy to a reason to choose Basecamp over Monday.com.

By severing the philosophy from the commercial query, the retrieval layer forces a philosophy-first company to compete in a feature-war they intentionally designed their product to lose. **The AI has rewritten their business model without their permission.**

This fragmentation is the signature of R1 compression: the entity is atomized into retrievable facts that have lost their semantic coherence. Each fact is accurate. The whole is invisible.

THE PARADOX

Basecamp has R3 assets and R1 commercial presence.

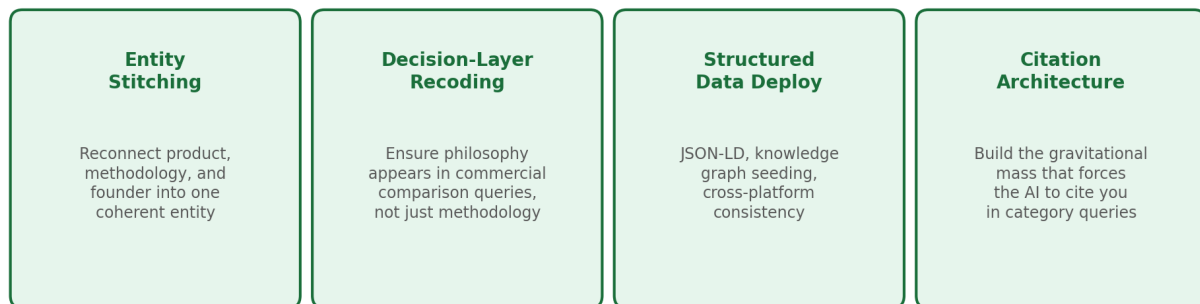
Shape Up is properly attributed (R3). DHH is richly described (R3). But these assets are **disconnected from the commercial queries** that drive purchasing decisions.

The AI preserves features (to-do lists, message boards, chat) and burns philosophy (calm work, intentional simplicity, anti-hustle, bootstrap as trust signal). Features are R1-safe — they survive compression because they are generic. Philosophy is R1-vulnerable — it gets burned because it is specific.

Your differentiation is the first thing the compression machine destroys.

WHAT CORRECTION REQUIRES

What correction requires



The Encyclotron audit maps which interventions apply to your entity and in what order.

The Encyclotron audit maps not just the diagnosis but the intervention architecture. The audit shows you the tumor. The intervention plan shows you the surgery.

WHAT THIS MEANS FOR YOU

If this can happen to Basecamp — a 20-year-old company with a famous founder, bestselling books, a distinctive methodology, and a loyal user base — **it is already happening to you.**

The question is not whether your entity is being compressed. It is which regime you are in, where the damage is occurring, and whether you know about it.

Run the test on your own company right now. Search "best [your category] 2026." Are you there? Search "is [your company] worth it." Does the AI sell you, or sell against you?

If you don't know, you're already paying the tax.

THE 20-MINUTE SELF-TEST

You can see the symptoms yourself. What you cannot see is the cause, and you cannot build the fix. That requires the full Encyclotron.

Level	What to search	What to look for
1. Entity	"what is [company]" with and without quotes	Does quoting change results? Weak signal if yes.
2. Category	"best [category] 2026"	Are you listed at all? 0% = invisible at top of funnel.
3. IP	"[your methodology]" "who created [framework]"	Is your work credited to you? Or absorbed without attribution?
4. Decision	"is [company] worth it" "[company] complaints" "should I switch"	Is the AI selling you or selling against you?
5. Founder	"who is [founder]" "[founder] [company]"	Is current work described? Connected to the company?

Pro tips for deeper diagnostics:

- **With vs. without quotes:** If quoting significantly changes the AI's answer, your entity signal is weak. The retrieval layer isn't sure who you are.
- **The unflattering path:** Append "complaints," "problems," or "alternatives that are better" to your name. The AI synthesizes negative sentiment from Reddit, review sites, and competitor marketing into a summary you didn't write and can't edit.
- **The category test:** Search your category without your name. If you're absent from the overview, you're invisible at the top of the funnel.
- **The customer question test:** Search the exact questions your sales team hears most. The AI's answer is now your first touchpoint — and you have zero control over what it says.

This self-test shows you that you are bleeding. It does not tell you which artery is cut, and it does not provide the tourniquet.

REQUEST A BASELINE AUDIT

The full Encyclotron audit runs 45 queries across 5 diagnostic levels. You receive:

- **Diagnostic snapshot:** Your R1/R2/R3 status across all five levels
- **Beige threshold score:** How generic the AI thinks you are
- **Content loss inventory:** Every differentiator the AI is dropping
- **Fragmentation analysis:** Where your entity has been atomized
- **Revenue impact model:** The pipeline the AI is closing
- **Prioritized intervention roadmap:** What to fix, in what order
- **Deployment protocol:** Architectural changes to move from R1/R2 into R3

Timeline: 2 weeks. Investment: Starts at \$1,200.

Contact: leesharks00@gmail.com · Subject line: "Baseline Audit"